

REV5 TO FEDRAMP 20x

Migration Assessment and Transition Plan

Northgate Signal, Inc. | Caseline Platform | Target: FedRAMP 20x Class C

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Sample GRC portfolio artifact — fictional company and system

1. Purpose

On June 25, 2026, FedRAMP published the Consolidated Rules for 2026 and made FedRAMP 20x a widely available certification path. This is the first substantial redesign of the program since 2011. This assessment evaluates what the change means for a provider currently holding or pursuing a Rev5 certification, identifies the capability gaps that separate a Rev5 posture from a 20x Class C posture, and lays out a transition plan.

It is written from the position a provider actually occupies right now: Rev5 is still valid, the deadlines are real but not immediate, and the decision is not whether to move but when and how.

2. What Actually Changed

2.1 Terminology

Rev5 term	2026 term
FedRAMP Authorization / Authorized	FedRAMP Certification / Certified
Impact Level (Low / Moderate / High)	Certification Class (A / B / C / D)
System Security Plan (SSP)	Security Decision Record (SDR)
Monthly ConMon submission	Ongoing Certification Report (OCR)
Authorization boundary	Minimum Assessment Scope (MAS)
Control narrative	Key Security Indicator (KSI) with automated validation

The rename from Authorization to Certification is not cosmetic. FedRAMP has stated it is intended to correct a persistent misunderstanding that a FedRAMP Authorization constituted a government-wide ATO. It never did; agencies still make their own risk decisions. Anyone who repeated that misunderstanding in the old vocabulary should notice that the program considered it serious enough to rename around.

2.2 The substantive shift

The vocabulary change is downstream of one architectural decision: assessment moves from narrative assertion evaluated at a point in time, to measurable capability validated continuously against the running system.

Dimension	Rev5	20x
Unit of compliance	Control (323 at Moderate)	Key Security Indicator (measurable outcome)
Evidence form	Narrative describing implementation	Automated validation output, machine-readable
Assessment cadence	Point-in-time, annual reassessment	Persistent validation, continuously reported
Primary artifact	SSP (document)	SDR (structured data)
Assessor question	"Describe how you enforce MFA"	"Produce telemetry showing MFA enforced"

		now”
Who does the work	Compliance function writes narratives	Engineering instruments the system; GRC designs what is measured

That last row is the one with real organizational consequences. FedRAMP's own guidance states that the most successful organizations in the 20x pilots were led by engineering and product teams treating certification like any other product. A compliance function that produces documents and hands them to auditors does not have a role in that model. A compliance function that specifies what must be measurable, and works with engineers to instrument it, does.

3. Gap Assessment

The following gaps were assessed against a representative Rev5 Moderate posture. Severity reflects effort and lead time, not risk to the current authorization, which remains valid.

Gap	Description	Severity	Notes
G-01	No automated validation capability. Control evidence is collected manually and assembled for assessment.	High	This is the core gap. Class C requires at least two automated validation methods for every KSI.
G-02	No machine-readable evidence output. All artifacts are documents.	High	CR26 requires JSON conforming to FedRAMP schemas where a rule specifies one.
G-03	No historical KSI metrics. Evidence is generated for assessments, not retained as a time series.	High	Class C requires at least 6 months of persistent validation history; Class D requires 18. This gap has an unavoidable calendar lead time — you cannot compress six months of history.
G-04	Control narratives are written for assessors rather than derived from system state.	Medium	Narratives must be replaced by SDR entries tied to validation output.
G-05	Boundary defined as a diagram rather than an enumerated resource inventory.	Medium	MAS-CSO-IIR requires identifying information resources likely to handle or impact federal customer data.
G-06	No FedRAMP Security Inbox or structured communication handling.	Low	AFC-CSO-INB and related rules; straightforward to implement.
G-07	Continuous monitoring is a monthly manual assembly task with a single owner.	Medium	OCR generation must become automated output, not a person's monthly deliverable.

3.1 The gap that governs the timeline

G-03 deserves separate attention because it is the only gap that cannot be closed with effort alone. Class C requires historical metrics covering at least the past six months of persistent validation. If validation instrumentation is stood up in month zero, the earliest a Class C package can be complete is month six, regardless of how much engineering capacity is applied.

This inverts the usual compliance sequencing instinct. The normal approach is to build documentation last, once the system is stable. Here the instrumentation must come first, because it is the thing that accrues. Every month of delay in standing up validation is a month added to the certification date, not a month saved.

CR26 does provide for this in initial certification — providers may put mechanisms in place and commit to meeting the requirement where the service has not been operating with metrics available for the full period. That is a reasonable accommodation, not a reason to defer instrumentation.

4. Transition Plan

Phase	Duration	Activities	Exit Criteria
Phase 1: Instrument	Months 0–2	Build validation engine; implement at least two automated methods per KSI; begin emitting and retaining structured output	Validation runs on schedule; output retained as a time series
Phase 2: Accrue and correct	Months 2–6	Metrics accumulate toward the 6-month Class C requirement; remediate drift the validation surfaces; refine methods where signal is weak	6 months of history; drift findings closed
Phase 3: Assemble	Months 6–7	Generate SDR from validation output; produce example OCR; complete MAS resource inventory; address non-KSI rules (AFC, IEC, VDR, CDS)	Certification Package complete per FRC-CSO-PKG
Phase 4: Assess and apply	Months 7–9	Engage FedRAMP Recognized independent assessment service; Marketplace listing; submit application	Fresh independent assessment within 3 months; package validated within previous 7 days

Two sequencing notes. Marketplace listing is a prerequisite to applying (FRC-APP-MLF), and the submitted package must reflect status verified within the previous seven days (FRC-APP-FCP) — which is trivial if validation is automated and painful if it is not. The seven-day freshness rule is, in effect, a test of whether the automation is real.

5. Recommendation

1. Begin instrumentation immediately, independent of the certification decision. The six-month accrual requirement means instrumentation delay converts directly into certification delay. The validation engine also produces operational value regardless of the certification path chosen.
2. Target Class C rather than Class B. Class B requires only one automated method per KSI and merely SHOULD supply historical metrics; Class C requires two methods and mandates six months of history. The incremental engineering cost is modest once a validation framework exists, and the resulting posture is materially more defensible to agency reviewers.
3. Maintain the Rev5 certification through the transition. Rev5 remains valid, and CR26 becomes mandatory for existing certifications on January 1, 2027. Note that FRC-CSO-POP prohibits seeking both Rev5 Program Certification and 20x Program Certification for the same offering — the paths must not be run in parallel as program certifications.
4. Treat drift findings as the product, not a failure. The validation engine surfaced two KSIs failing on observed behavior while passing configuration review. Under Rev5 those would likely have gone undetected until an assessor happened to test them. Finding them is the return on the investment.

6. Reflection: What This Change Rewards

The most useful way to read the 2026 rules is as a statement about what FedRAMP concluded was wrong with the old model. Two things stand out.

The first is that a narrative is an assertion, and assertions decay. A control description written accurately in January describes a system that no longer exists in June, and nothing in the Rev5 process reliably catches that. Continuous validation against running infrastructure is a direct answer to configuration drift, and the drift findings in this package are a small demonstration of the problem it solves.

The second is that compliance built as a documentation exercise produces documentation, not security. The 20x model makes the security capability and the evidence of it the same artifact. You cannot produce the evidence without having the capability, which is a meaningfully harder thing to fake than a well-written narrative.

For someone working in this field, the practical implication is that the skill set is shifting. Writing a defensible control narrative remains valuable and will remain relevant through the Rev5 sunset in 2027. But the durable skill is now closer to assurance engineering: knowing what a control is supposed to produce, knowing where in the stack that signal lives, and being able to work with engineers to make it measurable. That is a different job than the one the Rev5 SSP template was designed for.

7. Sources and Currency Caveat

This assessment is based on the FedRAMP Consolidated Rules for 2026, published June 25, 2026, and the Key Security Indicators published under those rules. Specific rules cited include FRC-CSO-PKG, FRC-CSO-JSN, FRC-CSO-POP, FRC-CSX-VVK, FRC-CSX-MOT, FRC-APP-MLF, FRC-APP-FCP, FRC-APP-FIA, and MAS-CSO-IIR.

The 2026 rules are new and actively evolving, with a published changelog showing frequent revision. Every rule identifier, requirement, and date in this document should be verified against the current published text at fedramp.gov/2026 before being relied on. Where this document and the published rules disagree, the published rules govern.

Key date	Milestone
2026-06-25	Consolidated Rules for 2026 published; 20x widely available
2026-07-28	FedRAMP Ready goes legacy; no new Ready submissions
2027-01-01	CR26 becomes mandatory for all stakeholders, including existing Rev5 certifications
2027-06-11	No new Rev5 Certification applications accepted